

Whiting (*Merlangius merlangus*) in Division 7.a (Irish Sea)

ICES advice on fishing opportunities

ICES advises that when the maximum sustainable yield (MSY) approach is applied, total removals in 2026 should be no more than 200 tonnes.

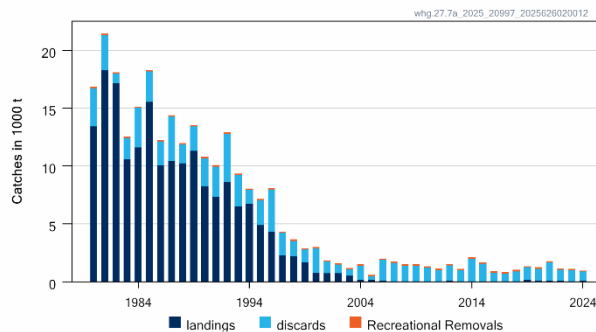
Non-fisheries conservation considerations

Conservation aspects and associated management measures may exist at a national or regional level but were not reviewed by ICES.

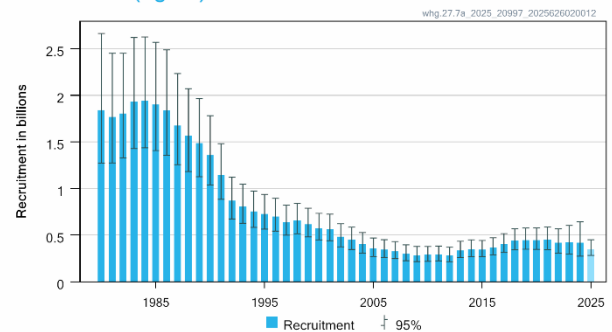
Stock development over time

Fishing pressure on the stock is above F_{MSY} and F_{PA} ; spawning-stock size is below $MSY B_{trigger}$, B_{PA} , and B_{lim} .

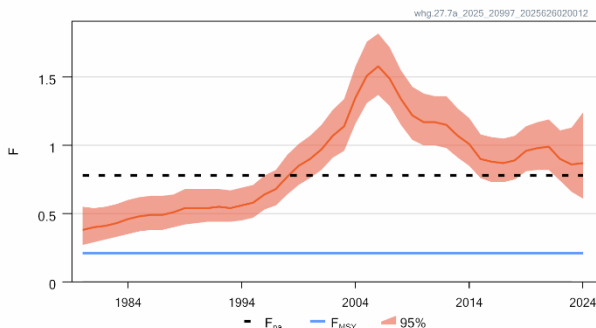
Catches



Recruitment (age 0)



F



SSB

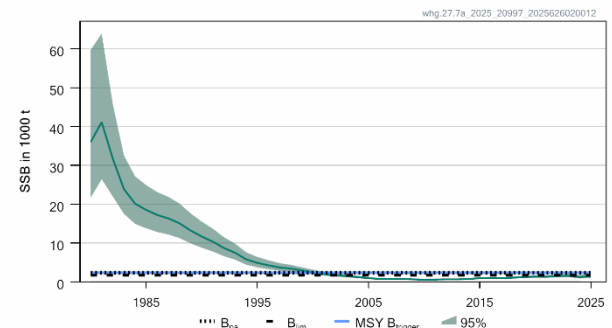


Figure 1 Whiting in Division 7.a. Summary of the stock assessment. The assumed recruitment value for 2025 is shaded in a lighter colour.

Catch scenarios

Table 1 Whiting in Division 7.a. Assumptions made for the interim year and in the forecast.

Variable	Value	Notes
$F_{ages\ 1-3}$ (2025)	0.87	Average exploitation pattern (2020–2024) scaled to $F_{ages\ 1-3}$ in 2024
Spawning-stock biomass (SSB; 2026)	1349	Short-term forecast; in tonnes
$R_{age\ 0}$ (2025, 2026)	347 936	Geometric mean (2004–2024); in thousands
Total removals (2025)	1191	Short-term forecast; in tonnes
Projected landings (2025)*	132	Short-term forecast assuming average landings ratio by age (2020–2024); in tonnes
Projected discards (2025)*	939	Short-term forecast assuming average discard ratio by age (2020–2024); in tonnes
Projected recreational removals	119	Based on ratio of commercial catch to recreational removals (2024)

* Adjusted by the ratio of commercial catch to recreational removals (2024)

Table 2 Whiting in Division 7.a. Annual catch scenarios. All weights are in tonnes. The percentage change in advice relative to 2025 is not provided because the 2025 advice was 0 tonnes.

Basis	Total catch (2026)	Projected landings (2026)	Projected discards (2026)	Projected recreational removals (2026) *	F total (2026)	Spawning -stock biomass (SSB; 2027)	% SSB change**	% total allowable catch (TAC) change ***	% probability of SSB (2027) < B _{lim} ^^
ICES advice basis									
Maximum sustainable yield (MSY) approach: $F_{MSY} \times SSB_{2026}/MSY B_{trigger}$	200	27	153	20	0.122	2109	56	-72	6.2
Other scenarios									
F_{MSY}	333	45	255	33	0.21	1975	46	-54	14.4
F_{PA}	1021	138	781	102	0.78	1333	-1.19	42	88
$F = 0$	0	0	0	0	0	2309	71	-100	1.40
$F_{MSY lower}$	259	35	198	26	0.160	2052	52	-64	9.8
$F_{MSY lower} \times SSB_{2026}/MSY B_{trigger}$	154	21	118	15	0.093	2155	60	-79	4.3
$SSB_{2027} = B_{lim}$	646	87	494	65	0.44	1670	24	-10.4	50
$SSB_{2027} = MSY B_{trigger} = B_{PA}^{\wedge}$									
$SSB_{2027} = SSB_{2026}$	1001	135	765	100	0.76	1349	0	39	86
$F = F_{2025}$	1107	150	847	111	0.87	1258	-6.8	54	93
$P(SSB(2027) < B_{lim}) = 5\%^{\dagger}$	164	22	125	16	0.099	2144	59	-77	5.0

* Recreational estimates are based on the proportion of catches attributed to recreational removals in 2024 (10%).

** SSB 2027 relative to SSB 2026.

*** Total advice in 2026 relative to the TAC in 2025 (721 tonnes).

^ The $MSY B_{trigger}$ and B_{pa} option was left blank because it can not be achieved in 2027, even with zero catch in 2026.

^^The probability of SSB being below B_{lim} in 2027. This probability relates to the short-term probability of $SSB < B_{lim}$ and is not comparable to the long-term probability of $SSB < B_{lim}$ tested in simulations when estimating fishing mortality reference points.

The increase from zero catch advice is due to a change in assessment method and the new reference points following the benchmark in 2025 (ICES 2025a).

Basis of the advice

Table 3 Whiting in Division 7.a. The basis of the advice.

Advice basis	Maximum sustainable yield (MSY) approach
Management plan	The EU multiannual plan (MAP) for stocks in Western Waters and adjacent waters (EU, 2019) takes into account bycatch of this species. There is no agreed shared management plan between the EU and UK for this stock, and ICES provides advice according to ICES MSY approach. Catch scenarios consistent with the MAP F_{MSY} ranges are provided.

Quality of the assessment

The stock was benchmarked in 2025 (ICES, 2025a), and the assessment model was changed to a state-space assessment model (SAM). Historical catch data were revised, new spatio-temporal modelled survey indices were included, and reference points were re-estimated. Recreational removals are now included in the assessment.

The NIGFS-WIBTS-Q4 survey coverage in 2024 was incomplete for technical reasons, and because of the extent of missing stations, the survey index was estimated excluding the 2024 data. Sensitivity analysis showed that the impact of the missing data on the assessment was negligible.

[†] Version 2: Extra catch scenario added in response to a special request from DGMARE

UK catch and sample data were revised for 2021–2023 but the overall impact on the assessment and short term forecast is considered negligible.

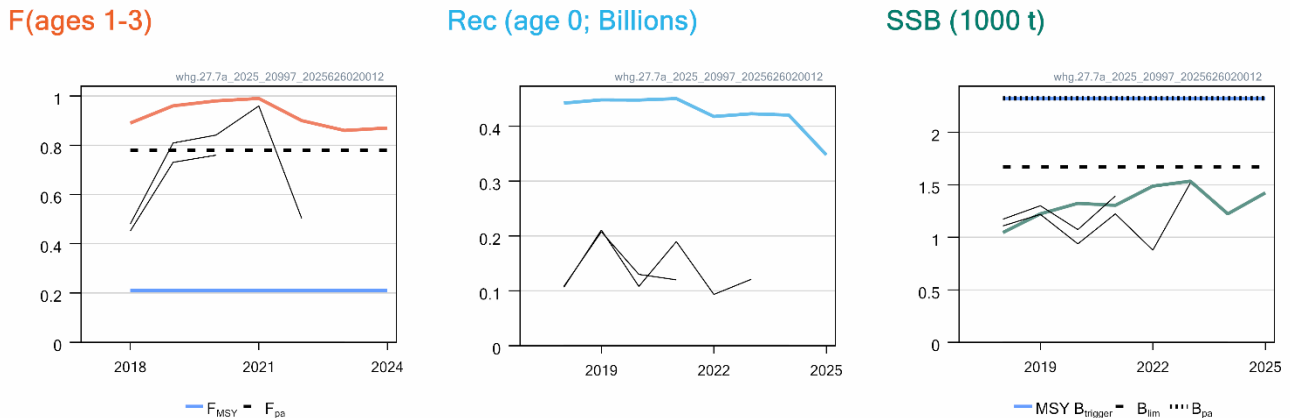


Figure 2 Whiting in Division 7.a. Historical assessment results (the final-year spawning-stock biomass [SSB] estimate and recruitment assumption included for each line). The assessment was benchmarked in 2025, prior to which a different method was applied. Reference points were also estimated in 2025. Only the last assessment should be compared with reference points.

Issues relevant for the advice

Recreational removals are calculated from retained recreational catch and the released fraction with estimated mortality. This value is included in the catch estimates in the assessment and should be considered as part of the catch advice. Recreational estimates in the advice are based on the proportion of catches attributed to recreational removals in 2024 (10%).

The assessment and the advice are for Division 7.a, excluding the rectangles 33E2 and 33E3, as whiting in these rectangles are considered to be part of the whiting 27.7b–ce–k stock (southern Celtic Seas and western English Channel). Landings data used in the whiting 27.7a assessment therefore explicitly exclude those reported from rectangles 33E2 and 33E3 (Table 6). Data from these rectangles are incorporated into the advice for whiting 27.7b–ce–k. In 2024, whiting landings in 33E2 and 33E3 represented 42% of the landings from division 7.a and constituted 0.8% of the landings from the whiting 27.7b–ce–k stock. The spatial limitation of the advice should be considered when setting total allowable catches (TACs) for the two management areas that span the whiting 27.7a and 27.7b–ce–k stocks.

Mixed fisheries considerations

Whiting in Division 7.a is caught as part of a mixed fishery with *Nephrops*, haddock, and cod (ICES, 2025b). The majority of whiting caught are discards in the *Nephrops* fishery and are below the minimum conservation reference size (MCRS).

Reference points

Table 4 Whiting in Division 7.a. Reference points, values, and their technical basis.

Framework	Reference point	Value	Technical basis	Source
Maximum sustainable yield (MSY) approach	MSY $B_{trigger}$	2322	B_{PA} ; in tonnes.	ICES (2025a)
	F_{MSY}	0.21	Stochastic simulations (using EQSIM)	ICES (2025a)
Precautionary approach	B_{lim}	1670	$0.15 \cdot B_0$; average B_{lim}/B_0 for gadoids; in tonnes	ICES (2025a)
	B_{PA}	2322	$B_{lim} \times \exp(1.645 \times \sigma)$; $\sigma = 0.2$; in tonnes.	ICES (2025a)
	F_{PA}	0.78	F with 95% probability of $SSB > B_{lim}$ (Beverton-Holt with $B_{trigger}$)	ICES (2025a)
Management plan	MAP MSY $B_{trigger}$	2322	MSY $B_{trigger}$; in tonnes	EU (2019), ICES (2025a)
	MAP B_{lim}	1670	B_{lim} ; in tonnes	EU (2019), ICES (2025a)
	MAP F_{MSY}	0.21	F_{MSY}	EU (2019), ICES (2025a)
	MAP range F_{lower}	0.16	Consistent with ranges resulting in no more than 5% reduction in long-term yield compared with MSY	EU (2019), ICES (2025a)

	MAP range F_{upper}	0.314	Consistent with ranges resulting in no more than 5% reduction in long-term yield compared with MSY	EU (2019), ICES (2025a)
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Basis of the assessment

Table 5 Whiting in Division 7.a. Basis of the assessment and advice.

ICES stock data category	1 (ICES, 2023)
Assessment type	Age-based analytical assessment: SAM* (Nielsen and Berg, 2014; ICES, 2025c).
Input data	Commercial catches (weights and ages); recreational removals; survey indices (NIGFS-WIBTS-Q1 [G7144], NIGFS-WIBTS-Q4 [G7655], NI MIK [I9826]); time varying maturity ogive; Lorenzen's natural mortality (Lorenzen, 1996)
Discards and bycatch	Included in the assessment for the full time-series
Recreational catches	Included in the assessment for the full time-series
Indicators	None
Other information	This stock was benchmarked in 2025 (ICES, 2025a)
Working group	Working Group for the Celtic Seas Ecoregion (WGCSE)

*[View assessment in Transparent Assessment Framework \(TAF\)](#).

History of the advice, catch, and management

Table 6 Whiting in Division 7.a. ICES advice, official landings, and estimated commercial landings and discards, and recreational removals. Weights are in tonnes.

Year	ICES advice	Catch corresponding to advice	Agreed TAC	Official landings	ICES landings***	Landings from 33E2 and 33E3***	ICES discards**	Recreational removals ##	ICES total removals
1987	Reduce F	16000	18170	11684	10411		3859	119	14389
1988	No increase in F; enforce mesh regulations	12000	18170	11492	10245		1611	119	11975
1989	F = F_{high} ; enforce mesh regulations	11000	18170	11328	11305		2103	119	13526
1990	No increase in F; TAC	8300*	15000	8183	8212		2444	119	10775
1991	Increase SSB to SSB(89)	6400*	10000	7411	7348		2598	119	10065
1992	80% of F(90)	9700*	10000	7094	8588		4203	119	12910
1993	70% of F(91) ~ 6 500 t	6500	8500	5977	6523		2707	119	9349
1994	Within safe biological limits	-	9900	5637	6763		1173	119	8055
1995	No increase in F	8300*	8000	5465	4893		2151	119	7163
1996	No increase in F	9800*	9000	5581	4335		3631	119	8085
1997	No advice given	-	7500	4472	2277		1928	119	4324
1998	20% reduction in F	3800#	5000	3355	2229		1304	119	3652
1999	Reduce F below F_{pa}	3500#	4410	1989	1670		1092	119	2881
2000	Reduce F below F_{pa}	< 1600#	2640	1130	762		2118	119	2999
2001	Lowest possible F	~0	1390	1066	733		1012	119	1864
2002	Lowest possible F	~0	1000	714	747		740	119	1606
2003	Lowest possible F	~0	500	554	517	159	542	119	1178
2004	Zero catch	0	514	204	133	51	1246	119	1498
2005	Zero catch	0	514	164	125	33	362	119	606
2006	Lowest possible catch	0	437	85	64	22	1808	119	1991
2007	Lowest possible catch	0	371	197	35	161	1588	119	1742
2008	Lowest possible catch	0	278	83	37	44	1342	119	1497
2009	Same advice as last year	0	209	102	39	63	1345	119	1503
2010	Same advice as last year	0	157	120	30	91	1195	119	1343
2011	See scenarios	-	118	107	31	75	982	119	1132
2012	Lowest possible catch and improve selectivity	0	89	72	60	43	1338	119	1517
2013	Lowest possible catch and improve selectivity	0	84	67	33	33	948	119	1100
2014	Same advice as for 2013	0	80	73	23	50	1951	119	2093
2015	Same advice as for 2013	0	80	59	28	34	1522	119	1669

Year	ICES advice	Catch corresponding to advice	Agreed TAC	Official landings	ICES landings***	Landings from 33E2 and 33E3***	ICES discards**	Recreational removals ##	ICES total removals
2016	Precautionary approach (minimize all catches)	0	80	55	15	40	770	128	913
2017	Precautionary approach	0	80	55	37	20	668	148	853
2018	Maximum sustainable yield (MSY) approach	0	80	63	46	18	853	120	1019
2019	MSY approach (same advice as for 2018)	0	727	67 ^c	172	24	1078	98	1349
2020	MSY approach	0	1246 [^]	103	88	14	1030	125	1243
2021	MSY approach	0	721	149	91	59	1571	111	1773
2022	MSY approach	0	721	51	57	21	987	118	1162
2023	MSY approach	0	721	63 ^{^^}	30	33	961	103	1094
2024	MSY approach	0	721	88 ^{^^}	62	26	813	98	973
2025	MSY approach	0	721						
2026	MSY approach	≤200 ^{^^^}							

* Not including discards from the *Nephrops* fishery.

** From the *Nephrops* fishery only from 1987 to 2002.

*** Including estimates of misreporting in 1992–2002 and, since 2003, landings from statistical rectangles 33E2 and 33E3 reallocated to whiting landings in divisions 27.7b–ce–k.

Landings only, no discards included.

Retained recreational catch and the released fraction with estimated mortality. Estimated for 2016–2024 and prior to that the mean recreational removals are assumed.

[^] TAC was increased mid-2019 from 727 t to 1246 t based on EU special request (ICES, 2019).

^{^^} Preliminary.

^{^^^} Includes commercial catch and recreational removals (taking mortality of released fish into account, estimated at approximately 35%).

^c Incomplete/missing as a result of part of the data being unavailable under data confidentiality clauses.

History of the catch and landings

Table 7 Whiting in Division 7.a. Catch distribution by fleet in 2024 as estimated by ICES.

Total removals	Landings*			Discards		Recreational removals
973 tonnes	Finfish-directed otter trawls	<i>Nephrops</i> -directed otter trawls	Other gears	<i>Nephrops</i> -directed otter trawls	Other gears	98 tonnes
	92%	4.0%	3.8%	92%	8.1%	
	62 tonnes			813 tonnes		

*Landings from statistical rectangles 33E2 and 33E3 reallocated to whiting landings in divisions 27.7b–ce–k.

Table 8 Whiting in Division 7.a. History of official landings by country. Weights are in tonnes.

Year	Belgium	France	Ireland	Netherlands	Spain	UK (NI, E&W)	UK (Isle of Man)	UK (Scotland)	UK	Landings from 33E2 and 33E3 **	Total official landings
1988	90	1063	4394			5823	15	107			11492
1989	92	533	3871			6652	26	154			11328
1990	142	528	2000			5202	75	236			8183
1991	53	611	2200			4250	74	223			7411
1992	78	509	2100			4089	44	274			7094
1993	50	255	1440			3859	55	318			5977
1994	80	163	1418			3724	44	208			5637
1995	92	169	1840			3125	41	198			5465
1996	80	78	1773	17		3557	28	48			5581
1997	47	86	1119	14		3152	24	30			4472
1998	52	81	1260	7		1900	33	22			3355
1999	46	150	509	6		1229	5	44			1989

Year	Belgium	France	Ireland	Netherlands	Spain	UK (NI, E&W)	UK (Isle of Man)	UK (Scotland)	UK	Landings from 33E2 and 33E3 **	Total official landings
2000	30	59	353	1		670	2	15			1130
2001	27	25	482			506	1	25			1066
2002	22	33	347			284	1	27			714
2003	13	29	265		85	130	1	31		159	554
2004	11	8	96			82	1	6		51	204
2005	10	13	94			47	0	< 0.5		33	164
2006	4	4	55			22	1	0		22	86
2007	3	3	187			3	1	0		161	197
2008	2	2	68			11	1	0		44	83
2009	2	1	78			20	0	0		63	102
2010	5	3	97			16	0	0		91	120
2011	4	2	95			5	0	0		75	107
2012	5	1	58			9	0	1		43	73
2013	2	< 0.5	44			18	0	2		33	67
2014	2	< 0.5	60			11	0	0		50	73
2015	1	< 0.5	49			-	0	-	8	34	59
2016	1	< 0.5	49			-	< 0.5	-	5	40	55
2017	2	< 0.5	33			-	4	-	17	20	55
2018	1	0	44			-	< 0.5	-	19	18	63
2019	4	0	0 ^c			-	< 0.5	-	63	24	67 ^c
2020	5	0	56			-	< 0.5	-	42	14	103
2021	2	< 0.5	109			-	0	-	38	59	149
2022	4	1	34			-	0	-	11	21	51
2023*	4	< 0.5	34			-	< 0.5	-	25	33	63
2024*	1	0	45			-	0	-	41	26	88

* Preliminary landings.

** Landings in the southern part of Division 7.a (statistical rectangles 33E2 and 33E3) are not included in the assessment and are considered to be part of the whiting stock in divisions 27.7b–ce–k.

^c Incomplete/missing as a result of part of the data being unavailable under data confidentiality clauses.

Table 9 Whiting in Division 7.a. History of ICES estimates of removals. Weights are in tonnes.

Year	Discards by country/fleet					ICES estimates of removals			
	<i>Nephrops</i> fishery [^]	Ireland	UK (NI)	Belgium	UK (E&W)	Discards	Landings	Recreational removals	Total
1988	1611					1611	10245	119	11856
1989	2103					2103	11305	119	13408
1990	2444					2444	8212	119	10656
1991	2598					2598	7348	119	9946
1992	4203					4203	8588	119	12791
1993	2707					2707	6523	119	9230
1994	1173					1173	6763	119	7936
1995	2151					2151	4893	119	7044
1996	3631					3631	4335	119	7966
1997	1928					1928	2277	119	4205
1998	1304					1304	2229	119	3533
1999	1092					1092	1670	119	2762
2000	2118					2118	762	119	2880
2001	1012					1012	733	119	1745
2002	740					740	747	119	1487
2003		480		59	3	542	517	119	1059
2004		905		127	215	1246	133	119	1379
2005		272		67	23	362	125	119	487
2006		1580	193	35	0	1808	64	119	1872
2007		725	787	15	61	1588	35	119	1623
2008		693	476	22	150	1342	37	119	1379
2009		688	633	0	24	1345	39	119	1384

Year	Discards by country/fleet					ICES estimates of removals			
	<i>Nephrops</i> fishery [^]	Ireland	UK (NI)	Belgium	UK (E&W)	Discards	Landings	Recreational removals	Total
2010		240	914	33	7	1195	30	119	1225
2011		330	616	33	3	982	31	119	1013
2012		257	1065	17	<0.5	1338	60	119	1398
2013		95	833	17	3	948	33	119	981
2014		263	1645	15	28	1951	23	119	1974
2015		438	1074	9	2	1522	28	119	1550
2016		173	589		8	770	15	128	785
2017		122	544		2	668	36	148	704
2018		98	754		1	853	46	120	899
2019		86	897	20	76	1078	172	98	1250
2020		102	906	22	0	1030	88	125	1118
2021		431	1118	22	0	1571	91	111	1662
2022		213	721	49	5	987	57	118	1044
2023		224	553	173	11	961	30	103	991
2024		148	619	47	0	813	62	98	875

[^] Based on UK (N. Ireland) and Ireland data.

Summary of the assessment

Table 10 Whiting in Division 7.a. Assessment summary. Weights are in tonnes, recruitment (age 0) in thousands. “High” and “low” refer to 95% confidence intervals.

Year	Recruitment			Spawning-stock biomass (SSB)			Discards	Landings	Recreational removals	Total removals	F (ages 1–3)		
	Low	Value	High	Low	Value	High					Low	Value	High
1980	1271780	1840444	2663381	21642	35951	59720	3314	13422	119	16856	0.27	0.38	0.55
1981	1274487	1767723	2451844	26425	41107	63947	3064	18267	119	21450	0.29	0.40	0.54
1982	1328096	1804670	2452258	21950	31685	45739	801	17167	119	18088	0.31	0.41	0.55
1983	1429055	1934920	2619855	17514	23878	32554	1829	10577	119	12524	0.33	0.43	0.57
1984	1437002	1942786	2626592	14910	20127	27171	3380	11619	119	15118	0.35	0.46	0.60
1985	1406888	1901106	2568935	13769	18515	24899	2644	15525	119	18288	0.37	0.48	0.62
1986	1357511	1838082	2488779	12819	17204	23089	2066	10063	119	12248	0.38	0.49	0.63
1987	1255764	1674848	2233792	12173	16309	21852	3859	10411	119	14389	0.38	0.49	0.63
1988	1182072	1564992	2071957	11254	15062	20159	1611	10245	119	11975	0.40	0.51	0.64
1989	1126757	1488448	1966243	9880	13194	17619	2103	11305	119	13526	0.42	0.54	0.68
1990	1036112	1358777	1781925	8766	11651	15485	2444	8212	119	10775	0.43	0.54	0.68
1991	884613	1144688	1481224	7785	10316	13668	2598	7348	119	10065	0.44	0.54	0.68
1992	672736	869272	1123225	6581	8687	11468	4203	8588	119	12910	0.44	0.55	0.68
1993	627257	809946	1045844	5686	7480	9842	2707	6523	119	9349	0.44	0.54	0.67
1994	582735	752561	971880	4393	5767	7570	1173	6763	119	8055	0.45	0.56	0.69
1995	564330	727067	936733	3718	4873	6387	2151	4893	119	7163	0.47	0.58	0.71
1996	543584	698131	896617	3234	4236	5548	3631	4335	119	8085	0.53	0.64	0.78
1997	500046	641174	822132	2826	3680	4791	1928	2277	119	4324	0.56	0.68	0.82
1998	514482	657986	841518	2622	3387	4374	1304	2229	119	3652	0.64	0.77	0.93
1999	481690	616521	789093	2286	2927	3748	1092	1670	119	2881	0.71	0.85	1.01
2000	447974	573669	734633	1912	2443	3121	2118	762	119	2999	0.76	0.90	1.07
2001	438858	564282	725553	1553	1980	2525	1012	733	119	1864	0.82	0.97	1.15
2002	374137	482731	622844	1345	1710	2174	740	747	119	1606	0.91	1.07	1.26
2003	345879	450209	586009	1147	1459	1855	542	517	119	1178	0.96	1.14	1.34
2004	307954	403071	527569	948	1214	1554	1246	133	119	1498	1.16	1.35	1.58
2005	271399	357384	470612	705	907	1168	362	125	119	606	1.31	1.51	1.76
2006	260957	343330	451704	574	742	959	1808	64	119	1991	1.37	1.58	1.82
2007	248244	326945	430598	584	755	975	1588	35	119	1742	1.29	1.49	1.72
2008	226347	299542	396406	578	750	973	1342	37	119	1497	1.15	1.34	1.55
2009	217363	287041	379055	476	621	809	1345	39	119	1503	1.04	1.22	1.43
2010	219458	288364	378906	416	541	703	1195	30	119	1343	1.00	1.17	1.38
2011	223114	292280	382887	450	579	744	982	31	119	1132	1.00	1.17	1.36
2012	215061	282854	372017	493	632	811	1338	60	119	1517	0.98	1.15	1.36

Year	Recruitment			Spawning-stock biomass (SSB)			Discards	Landings	Recreational removals	Total removals	F (ages 1–3)		
	Low	Value	High	Low	Value	High					Low	Value	High
2013	258744	335619	435336	476	617	800	948	33	119	1100	0.91	1.07	1.27
2014	269576	347924	449043	555	716	923	1951	23	119	2093	0.85	1.01	1.20
2015	268445	345009	443410	716	920	1183	1522	28	119	1669	0.76	0.90	1.08
2016	288471	369339	472877	765	981	1257	770	15	128	913	0.73	0.88	1.06
2017	314370	403085	516836	745	947	1205	668	37	148	853	0.73	0.87	1.05
2018	343901	442346	568972	828	1045	1319	853	46	120	1019	0.75	0.89	1.07
2019	348904	448319	576063	965	1223	1550	1078	172	98	1349	0.81	0.96	1.14
2020	346959	448004	578476	1039	1323	1686	1030	88	125	1243	0.82	0.98	1.17
2021	345044	450565	588355	1018	1304	1670	1571	91	111	1773	0.82	0.99	1.19
2022	307899	417956	567354	1159	1487	1907	987	57	118	1162	0.74	0.90	1.11
2023	295500	422970	605427	1160	1534	2028	961	30	103	1094	0.66	0.86	1.13
2024	274363	420535	644583	866	1223	1727	813	62	98	973	0.61	0.87	1.24
2025	282879*	347936*	450530*	912	1423	2220							

* Geometric mean recruitment 2004–2024.

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Recommended citation: ICES. 2025. Whiting (*Merlangius merlangus*) in Division 7.a (Irish Sea). *In* Report of the ICES Advisory Committee, 2025. ICES Advice 2025, whg.27.7a. <https://doi.org/10.17895/ices.advice.27202947>